Software Solutions for Business

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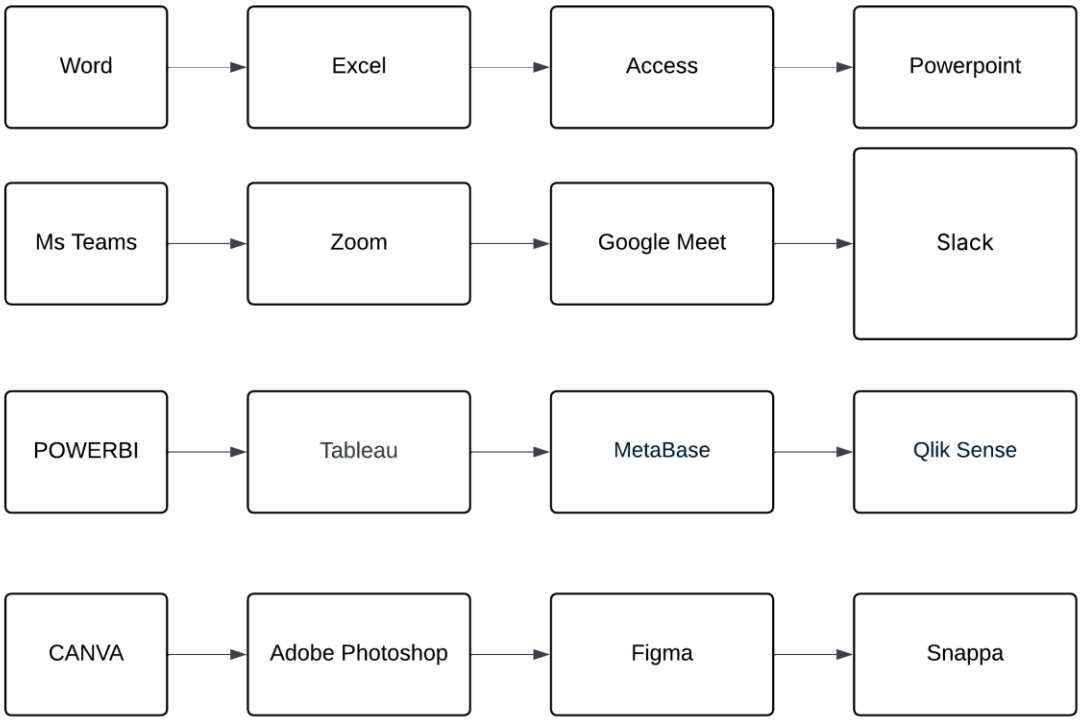
1. Task 1 – e-Commerce Website Builders / Software Solutions (~500 words)

E-commerce website builders allow individuals and businesses to create online stores to sell products and services on the internet. You do not have to be a web developer as many builders can be simple in use. Users are not required to have pre-existing coding knowledge, nor will they need to learn by learning Java, HTML & CSS. Wix is used by businesses due to being a simplistic drag and drop editor, suitable for most users due to its ease of use, whilst also still allowing users to create professionally designed websites as it comes equipped with over 2000 templates with over 300 being free.[1][2] Shopify offers the same features of Wix however it is hailed as the primary E-commerce website builder by business as it has been acknowledged as “a 360 solution that tackles everything from managing payment gateways to providing APIs to create native shoppable experiences with social media platforms and wholesale marketplaces, manage email outreach, review aggregation, and more.”[3] It’s mixed payment choices ; Apple Pay, Google play, heightening accessibility to multiple users, PayPal, credit cards to name a few, the flexibility increases sales for business as a byproduct as it improves customer satisfaction, due to accommodating customers preferences.[4] Additionally E-commerce have the capability to support alternative transaction types purchase option to sell products on a recurring basis, and customers can choose to pay an agreed price for your product in a fixed frequency for example a gym membership that will be paid on 25/Oct on a monthly, weekly, or daily basis. A generous benefit for businesses as they will have recurring revenue, generating forecasts or sales predictions, analyzing trends, so much more with the integrated system or exporting such data to Excel and relevant database management software[5]. In fact, both websites already happen to track and analyze costumer behavior due to accessing customers data, which should improve marketing efforts and business strategies[6] Wix in particular has a higher tier, “Wix Ascend, said to be an “all-in-one CRM and marketing product suite that allows you to connect with consumers and turn them into paying customers through lead capture, loyalty schemes and return visits, and build and manage your mailing lists” which integrates how they can charm, manage and retain customers through a loyalty scheme for example, a business has no need to find new customers if they have a loyal fanbase returning. The mailing list allows businesses to promote/advertise content like

promotions and special offers directly, leading to repeat purchases as customers return[1]. All if not most physical retailers must heavily rely on E-commerce platforms for their business, by selling online, a store is now available 24/7, allowing customers to shop at any time without requiring additional staff or extended shifts as well as reducing if not eliminating travel time for customers. For small businesses, this will now reduce the need of renting or buying a physical space which is cost effective as they may use the addition wealth for other purposes, lastly, there will be room for less staffing, and removing the former restricted customer reach as now you have a global presence rather than a local, enabling customers worldwide, breaking geographical barriers.[6]

2. Task 2 – Mind-map of Contemporary Software Applications (~500 words)

Mind mapping is a visual method of shaping information, using a dominant idea, and branching topics to represent related ideas. Essentially Mind Mapping ‘maps’ out your thoughts to encourage further ideas. They make it easier to present your ideas from your mind into something visible and structured which for businesses conducting presentations or collaborating on a project, mind mapping makes it simpler to learn quicker, brainstorm faster, and link ideas more efficiently. It is stated that mind mapping saves you time and improves the quality of your work, which is supported by Chuck Frey who conducted a survey which had 695 participants take part in a survey which yielded the following results. 46.8% percent of his population size stated that “mind mapping has had a significant effect on the way in which they work. Participants “cited an average productivity increase of 30%” from using mind maps. Another 17% said it has had a revolutionary effect” and additionally 59.6% was said to have confessed that they would not be able to produce the same quality of work if they didn’t have the option to mind map showcasing its strength in the business world.[7][8][9] Collaboration is supplemented by Mind maps being freely available and accessible online, Mind Meister for example is completely web-based, meaning it is accessible to all users as long as they have a stable internet connection and a device that supports search engines, so employees may create, edit, and share mind maps directly through their browser without installing additional software, eliminating any operating system compatibility of smartphones systems like Android or Ios, which makes access simple and convenient across different devices. Its key strengths lies in its real-time collaboration; multiple users can work on the same mind map simultaneously, which benefits team projects, meetings, and much more, which is especially useful in remote working environments. Mind Meister also can integrate with cloud storage services such as Google Drive which allows users to save, synchronise, and share their mind maps alongside any other project files, benefits a business. As I mentioned briefly, not only can you share a mind map directly, but you can also export/send into various formats for example, PDF, images, and presentations, making it easier to incorporate ideas into reports, slideshows, or whatever needs to be.[10]Lastly mind maps are highly effective for brainstorming, and breaking down complex challenges into manageable parts, which is particularly useful within business, breaking down your goals into manageable pieces can allow users to further break down their ideas into actionable steps by visually tracking progress and altering strategies if needed, users can now stay motivated and focused, strengthening the likelihood of achieving success. Mind map’s ability to reduce complex information into simplified images that should be easier understood when presented to, reducing the must for lengthy reports or explanations, starting goals of with mind mapping could also reinforce less misunderstandings during planning and finishing phases of a project. Inconclusion, mind mapping influences improved planning, team-collaboration, and more accurate decision making throughout business operations.


Word
Excel
Access
Powerpoint
Ms Teams
Zoom
Google Meet
Slack
POWERBI
Tableau
MetaBase
Qlik Sense
CANVA
Adobe Photoshop
Figma
Snappa

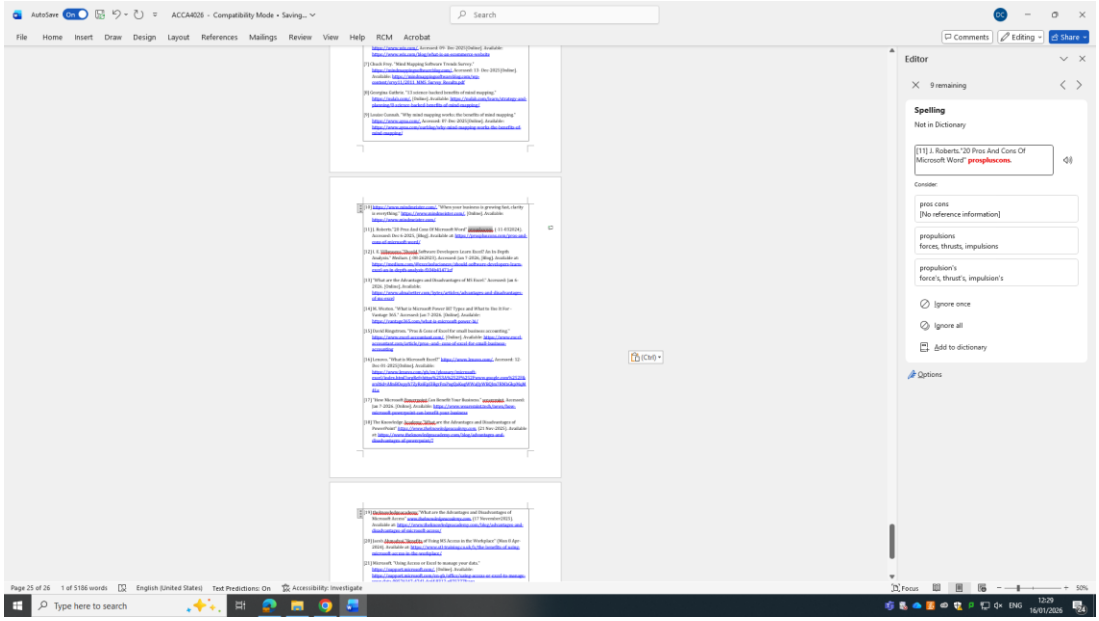
3. Task 3 – Office Applications for Creating, Storing, Presenting & Analyzing Data

Microsoft Word is one of the most popular applications within the Microsoft Office suite due to it's easy to navigate interface equipped with flexible features, such as inserting images and customizing documents with different colors, fonts, and styles. Templates can also range from CVs/Resumes to marketing brochures[11]. It continues to remain popular and vastly used across the world, it may be used by businesses to construct letters and make invoices or in education where students and lecturers may also work on essays, assignments, or reports. For multiple businesses, its strongest advantage would be that Microsoft Word is compatible with all the other Suite applications such as Excel or Outlook[11].

One of Microsoft Word's key strengths in business operations is its strong integration with other Microsoft Office applications, as previously mentioned, Excel to insert Excel tables and charts, which reduces the workload and possible errors as you are importing directly from Excel, which also smooths out the workflow for projects requiring data analysis or presentation preparation.[11]

Lastly Microsoft's One drive is also a widely used Cloud storage, it can sync and autosave documents in real time whilst also offering real time collaboration, leaving notes or comments as well, for the business world this feature boosts team productivity and makes it easy to share documents, eliminating the need to consistently send reformatted and updates documents via email, Additionally as previously mentioned OneDrive's autosave minimizes the risk of data loss, since every change is saved automatically, making it helpful during longer projects or collaborative efforts.[11]

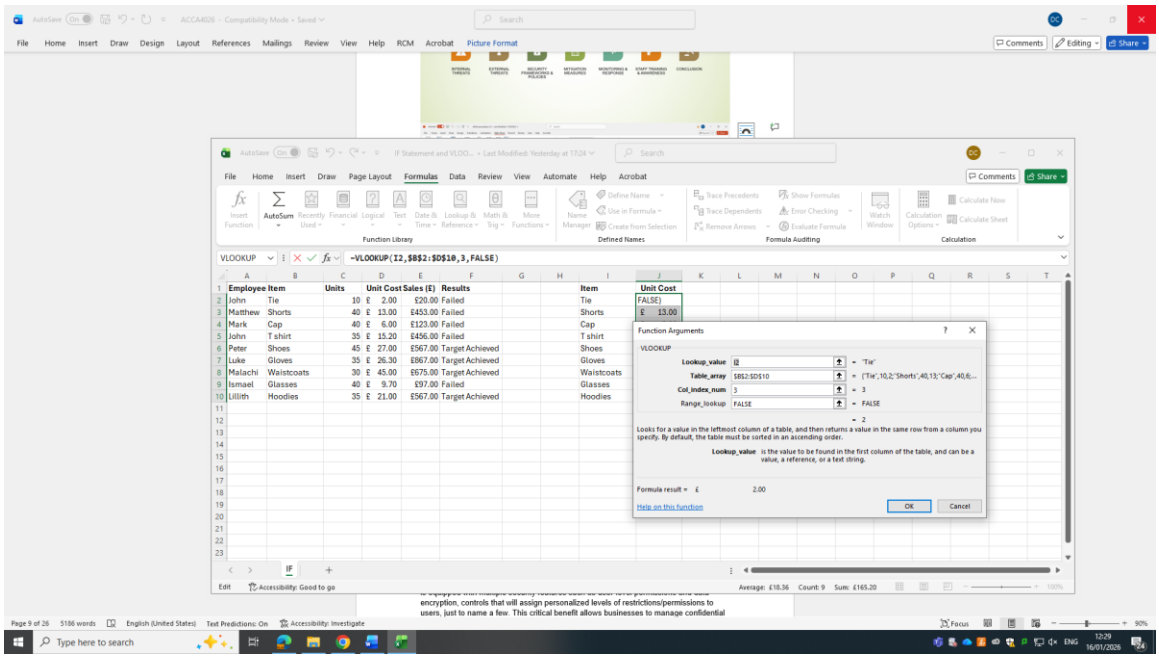
However, there are significant limitations to Word, it is also a subscription-based platform, the price which may be costly for individuals, students, or small businesses. The requirement to pay for the desktop version may not be justifiable for users who only require basic words basic features so the free alternative platforms such as Google Docs would be much more viable, but compatibility issues may arise when alternative platforms are unable to open the word file format/file type, which may disrupt workflow and destroying the chance for collaborative work on a high level such as maybe lacking real time collaboration.



Word’s built in Spelling and grammar checker

Microsoft Excel, it’s the most widely used spreadsheet program in the world, Microsoft Excel for over a decade has been extensively used in accounting, administrative, essentially all types of businesses.[12] Its resourcefulness has proven itself such as its Data Analysis Tools, consisting of but not limited to; “statistical functions, regression analysis, goal seeking, scenario management, and solving, aiding in complex data analysis and decision-making”.[13] Excels very extensive compatibility to seamlessly integrate with a wide range of computer programming languages such as python or SQL and the platform **Microsoft Power BI**[12] Businesses use Power BI for data visualization and business intelligence. Enabling users to convert data into images for greater comprehension and decision-making. It is designed for both data experts and average individuals, with the goal of making data analytics more accessible to everyone. Excel with Power BI can track performance, predict trends and much more.[14] It has helped business provide a way to showcase their data in spreadsheets in a visually appealing, simplistic way such as Pie Charts or Bar charts, an array of representations to show data to the user’s goal[15]. Another powerful benefit that is utilized rigorously by companies is its ability to share your workbook, granting them control to view, edit, or comment on your projects. Another useful ability is to “assign tasks to other users or have them assign tasks to you so everyone stays on the same page”.[16] Teams will be able to work at an increased pace whilst also having the ability to auto save, thus elimination the risk of losing changes.[16].Unfortunately Excels limitations lies in its inability to handle large datasets efficiently, down the line will lead to “performance issues and potential data loss or corruption”. In line with corruption, Excel files often lack forceful security features, making them vulnerable to unauthorized access, data breaches, or accidental alterations.[13] Business may also not have tech-savvy users, or may not have the resources to train its employees, even though it's user friendly for

basic operations, performing complex operations would require advanced knowledge of formulas, functions, programming knowledge if one wishes to automate tasks.[13]



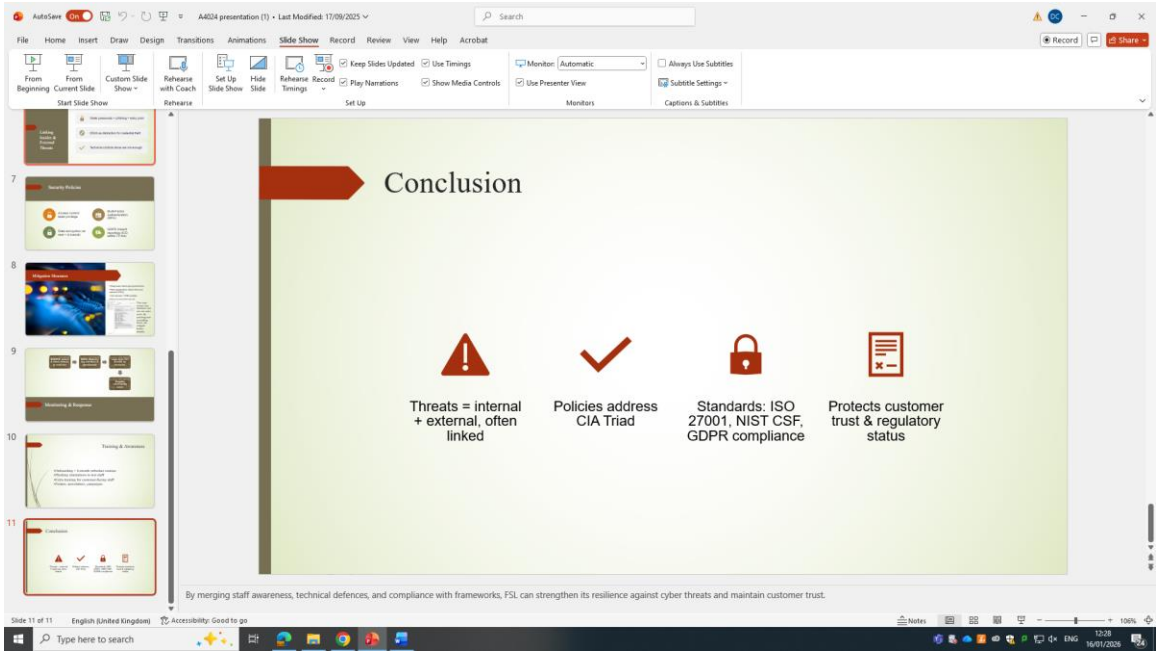
VLOOKUP

Microsoft PowerPoint

As with all Suite applications, **PowerPoint** is used in business, education, and the average individual. It's ability to create clear, concise and well-structured slideshow-based presentations in a short space of time even if the user is not tech savvy.[17] PowerPoint's biggest strength lies in its ability for content to be visualized, giving the user full power over its large preinstalled "design templates, color schemes, and graphical elements".[18] Thus completely removing information overload one might experience from "too much writing" or help articulate the speakers points in a more bullet type approach, removing over complicated explanations, This ensures that the audience viewing the presentation will have a cohesive experience regardless of who is making the presentation.[17] For businesses, conveying information now has the opportunity to no longer be compact reports or lengthy verbal explanations, thus boosting productivity and reducing everyone's time. Another highlight is its "File conversion**."** **"**PowerPoint Presentations can be easily converted to different file formats, offering flexibility in sharing and distribution. Whether you need to share your presentation with colleagues, clients, or a wider audience, PowerPoint enables you to save your slides in formats such as PDFs, video files, or even images."[18] Even though PowerPoint is popular, not everyone uses it or even, some may not use it all, having the option to export shows as PDF or pictures/images which allows all users or potential clients to open the files on virtually any device (smartphone, tablet, PC) without any formatting errors. As a video business, it can just upload the same content but in Media (Video) format online or on social media profiles (TikTok or Instagram) which saves time and reduces workload on

staff from having to rebuild anything from scratch. However, it does come with its negatives, I mentioned Information overload when approaching traditional methods of receiving data information, if the presenter is struggling to summarize their point, they may be forced to include all information, trivial and vital, which may also cause the audience to be feel overwhelmed, completely reversing the whole point of the PowerPoint in the first place. This can be overcome with inserting tables or charts, as it also integrates very well with **Excel** amongst other software. With its pre-installed templates, it is possible to show interesting presentations of data more fitting for the given situation.[18] Excel can be linked to PowerPoint for automatic updates, individuals can but are not limited to using a line chart to perhaps show how their respective company is doing this quarter, particularly with sales and figures or their performance over the years. I mentioned before that it's built in file conversion makes it much easier for corporations to distribute PowerPoint and it supports cross-platform viewership. Its flexibility is a key benefit to remote clients as well due to its ease of shareability, "Whether you choose to use email, file-sharing platforms, or cloud storage solutions like OneDrive or Google Drive, PowerPoint's compatibility allows you to collaborate with others and share your presentations effortlessly". This leads to staff to then work on a presentation in real-time from wherever they may be working from, making it ideal for team projects or group presentations. Although PowerPoint can encounter "technical issues or compatibility problems," which could disrupt a presentation which is not what is wanted. Errors may arise such as when formatting breaks, fonts fail to load, or media does not correctly play such as animations and transitions across different devices or software versions. These critical issues highlight that despite strong collaboration and cross-platform benefits with the boost of Cloud based interaction, smooth performance on different devices/systems is not always guaranteed.[18]

PowerPoint Presentation



Home Screen

Microsoft Access

Microsoft Access was at one point the most powerful Database Management Systems globally, its relative ease of use and a not so steep learning curve, makes it user-friendly for the average employee.[19] As with many if not all **Microsoft Suite** it houses a similar layout thus allowing users to be familiar with the system as if it were **Excel**, using Access, users may straightforwardly create, manage, and manipulate databases, which helps in shaping large volumes of data professionally. A key highlight which is beneficial

for businesses that must maintain detailed records, track inventory, or manage customer information.[20] Access also works seamlessly with **PowerPoint** and **Excel**. Excel and Access can be deployed adjacently; Excel can be used for analyzing data whilst performing complex calculations which is a major obstacle for Access as it is lackluster when it comes to performing complex querying or if you “frequently run calculations and statistical comparisons on your data”[19][21]. In the current Cyber world, there has been a noticeable surge in data breaches, manipulation of records and unauthorized cyber-attacks attempts into corporations. Microsoft Access is equipped with multiple security features such as user-level permissions and data encryption, controls that will assign personalized levels of restrictions/permissions to users, just to name a few. This critical benefit allows businesses to manage confidential information, access ensures security measures are in compliance with confidentiality, integrity, and other such regulations.[19][20]. However, businesses may still choose to opt to a more advanced database due to its inability to process business needs of larger scaled data handling for the respective business, so in that case a stronger database system is made for processing complex scenarios.[19]

Overall, Microsoft Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Access each application seamlessly integrates with each other, justifying its price for businesses to purchase its subscription-based payment. It is the best of all worlds, due to being connected to each other, reducing the need of purchasing multiple software and learning how to use said alternative application, due to possibly being complex in use, or possibly having file conversion errors or formatting errors. Word allows businesses to create formal documents with the freedom to choose multiple templates such as letters or resumes or reports, Excel supports creating spreadsheets for budgets and sales revenue to give an example. PowerPoint allows users to display their information, data etc., to be presented clearly to specific demographics. Lastly, Access provides a stable database for organizing and storing relational data. The Microsoft Office suite combined enables a stable stream that allows business to accurately manipulate their work all in one, which can improve productivity, accuracy, and collaboration for businesses. However, since it comes with limitations and multiple downsides that the software can’t be used to support larger corporations, they must opt for more advanced or specialized applications. Although, Microsoft Office applications still reign as being widely throughout the business world, simply because of their long-term familiarity, compatibility with each other and the ability to support a range of everyday tasks, ranging from simple to complex, aiding small business and large whilst also, surviving the test of time due to their numerous updates.

3.2 Excel Practical Evidence – Pick any TWO of the following features and document your own testing:

IF Function (Excel)

I used Microsoft Excel; I created a small dataset; I used ten employees and their sales figures to show the IF function in a practical scenario. The target was to check whether each employee achieved a sales target of £500 or anything higher and show their result, labelled either as “Target Achieved” or “Failed”.

The (Descending starting from figure A) first screenshot shows the dataset before applying the IF Function is in use, to show the before and after, notice column F, displaying an empty “Result” column where the output will appear. The second screenshot displays the Function Arguments box for the IF function, where I entered the logical test E2>=500, so if the sales figure were greater than or equal to £500, the function would output “Target Achieved”, IF not, it would display “Failed”. Additionally, the autofill feature removes the need to manually compare each value which can be seen in the fifth screenshot below allowing Excel to automate the allocated task. The final screenshot shows the completed results after selecting and dragging the function down the column. Employees who have met the target were labelled as “Target Achieved,” while the latter were marked as “Failed.”

F2

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	**Employee**	**Item**	**Units**	**Unit Cost**	**Sales (£)**	**Result**	
2	John	Tie	10	£ 2.00	£20.00		
3	Matthew	Shorts	40	£ 13.00	£453.00		
4	Mark	Cap	40	£ 6.00	£123.00		
5	John	T shirt	35	£ 15.20	£456.00		
6	Peter	Shoes	45	£ 27.00	£567.00		
7	Luke	Gloves	35	£ 26.30	£867.00		
8	Malachi	Waistcoats	30	£ 45.00	£675.00		
9	Ismael	Glasses	40	£ 9.70	£97.00		
10	Lillith	Hoodies	35	£ 21.00	£567.00		

Figure A Screenshot 1

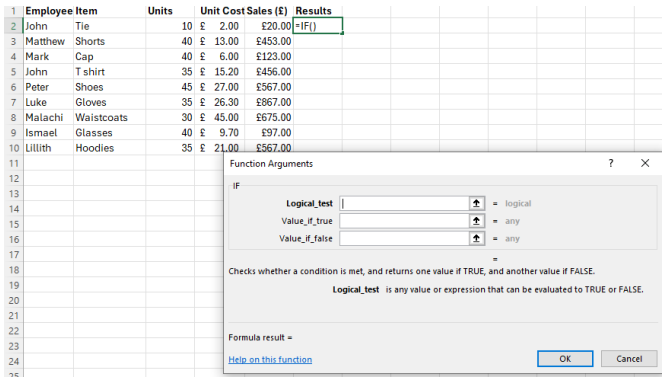


Figure A Screenshot 2

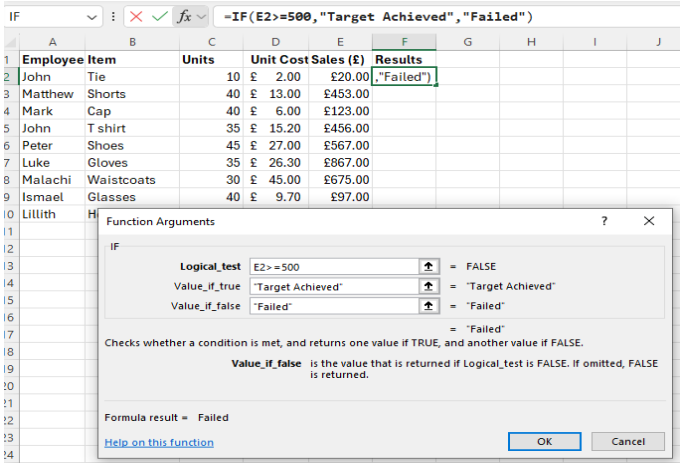


Figure A Screenshot 3

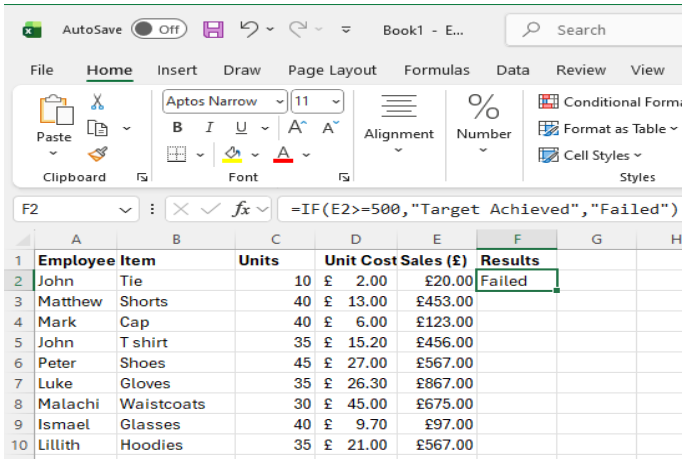


Figure A Screenshot 4

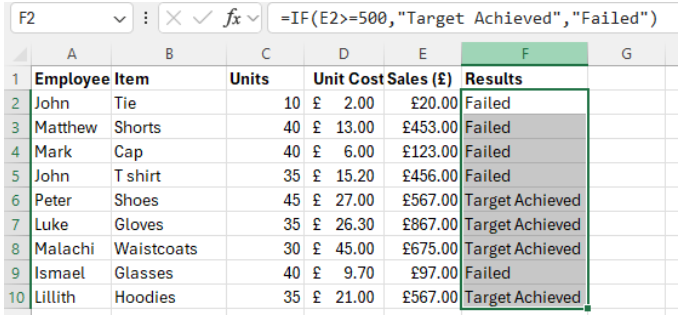
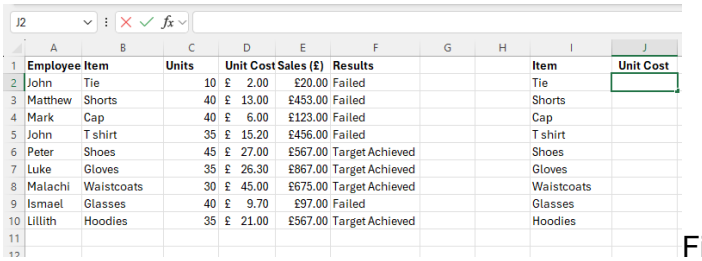


Figure A Screenshot 5

VLOOKUP (Excel)

I used Microsoft Excel to demonstrate the VLOOKUP function using my existing sales dataset from the IF function. I managed to automatically return the correct unit cost for each item that the employees sold, instead of manually checking the values. The same ten employees each had an associated item that they sold (e.g. Tie, Shorts, Cap, etc.) so I used VLOOKUP to automatically retrieve the unit cost for each item instead of entering the prices manually. The (Descending starting from figure B) first screenshot shows the dataset and the items each employee sold before the VLOOKUP function was used. In the second screenshot, the formula bar shows the VLOOKUP function being entered. I used =VLOOKUP(I2,$B$2:$D$10,3,FALSE), where I2 contains the item being searched, and the table array $B$2:$D$10 contains the item names and their unit costs, Wherever the $ is used, my formula if it where to be moved or copy, VLOOOKUP refers to cell B2 to D10.The Col_index_num “3” returns the value from the third column (Unit Cost), and “FALSE” ensures an exact match. Once the function was used, Excel returned the correct price for the item “Tie”, which was £2.00. The autofill feature removed the need to type each price manually, as seen in Figure B screenshot 6, where dragging the formula down allowed Excel to fill the Unit Cost for the remaining items. The final screenshot shows the completed results after the VLOOKUP function was applied to the full list.



Employee	Item	Units	Unit Cost	Sales (£)	Results			Item	Unit Cost
John	Tie	10	£ 2.00	£20.00	Failed			Tie	
Matthew	Shorts	40	£ 13.00	£453.00	Failed			Shorts	
Mark	Cap	40	£ 6.00	£123.00	Failed			Cap	
John	T shirt	35	£ 15.20	£456.00	Failed			T shirt	
Peter	Shoes	45	£ 27.00	£567.00	Target Achieved			Shoes	
Luke	Gloves	35	£ 26.30	£867.00	Target Achieved			Gloves	
Malachi	Waistcoats	30	£ 45.00	£675.00	Target Achieved			Waistcoats	
Ismael	Glasses	40	£ 9.70	£97.00	Failed			Glasses	
Lillith	Hoodies	35	£ 21.00	£567.00	Target Achieved			Hoodies	

Figure B screenshot 1

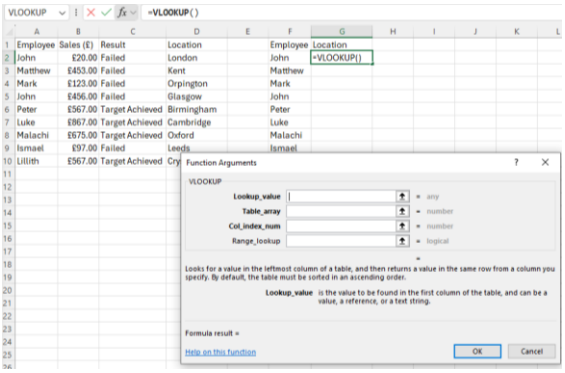


Figure B screenshot 2

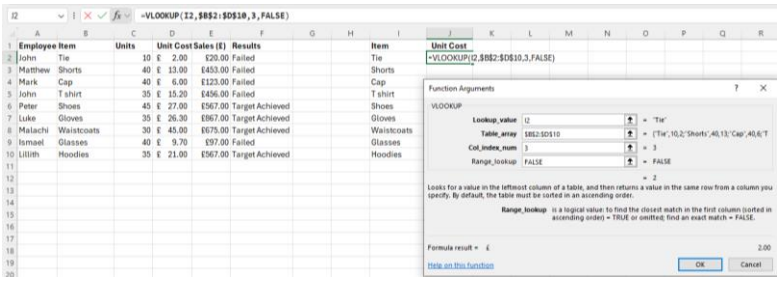
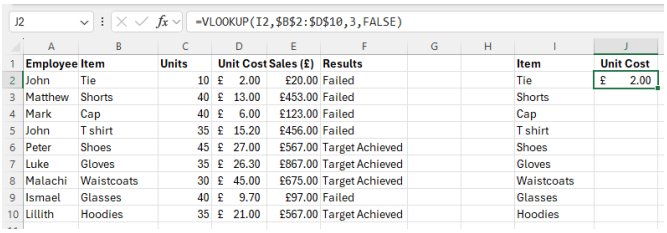


Figure B screenshot 3



Employee	Item	Units	Unit Cost	Sales (£)	Results			Item	Unit Cost
John	Tie	10	£ 2.00	£20.00	Failed			Tie	£ 2.00
Matthew	Shorts	40	£ 13.00	£453.00	Failed			Shorts	
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John	T shirt	35	£ 15.20	£456.00	Failed			T shirt	
Peter	Shoes	45	£ 27.00	£567.00	Target Achieved			Shoes	
Luke	Gloves	35	£ 26.30	£867.00	Target Achieved			Gloves	
Malachi	Waistcoats	30	£ 45.00	£675.00	Target Achieved			Waistcoats	
Ismael	Glasses	40	£ 9.70	£97.00	Failed			Glasses	
Lillith	Hoodies	35	£ 21.00	£567.00	Target Achieved			Hoodies	

Figure B screenshot 4

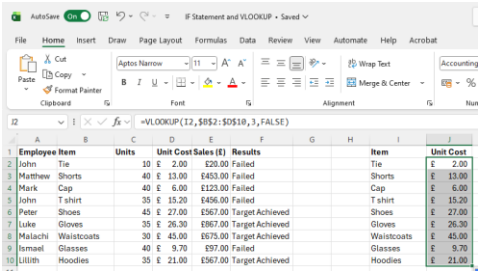

Figure B screenshot 4

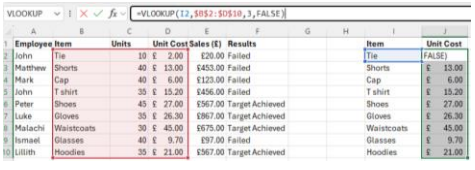

Figure B screenshot 6

4. Task 4 – Communication & Collaboration Applications (~1000 words)

4.1 Analyse one contemporary Communication and one Online Collaboration applications/tools used frequently in modern business world and document a summary of their key features using written text with some images and relevant citations.

Microsoft Teams – Key Features for Modern Business Communication

Microsoft Teams is both a communication and collaboration platform[22], thus offering a vast array of features such as file sharing, recording meetings, loop components and its main most used featured, the ability to host video conferences with a multitude of people. As with a majority of the Microsoft Office suite, it integrates seamlessly with a range of applications like Word or PowerPoint, since it is included in the MS Suite, it comes with no extra cost due to being within an already pre-established subscriptions-based suite. Microsoft products are highly used within the business world so since most businesses will already have a Microsoft 365 license, they will feel like it's the cheaper option to opt for Teams rather than their competitors with less features such as Slack or Googles alternative[23]. Additionally, as a side it is both a communication and collaboration application, so it is already equipped with the option to have a video call or make an audio call, from anywhere and to anyone globally. Teams is available on multiple devices, desktop computers, laptops, tablets and even smartphones, it is operatable on several systems and operating systems like Ios and MacOS but not Linux unfortunately, however Teams is highly beneficial in this regard as it is flexible for many users and they can stay connected on the move due to being available on smartphones and tablets, extremely handy for the day to day travel.[24] This is not without its drawbacks as WIFI/mobile data issues will circumvent any and all Teams features, unstable connection interferes with presentations and collaboration on documents and etc. Additionally, the businesses will have to pay an additional fee to gain access to premium phone plans and business chats so it may not be viable for smaller businesses

or businesses that don't have the Microsoft suite.[24] Teams essentially provides the best of both worlds, allowing employees to host virtual face-to-face interviews with the added benefit of muting the audio, choosing the background and or adding multiple users, something that it can do that many other applications fail to replicate is it's built in live transcription, showing the audience real time text of spoken words, with timestamps users may go back to key details, take notes more accurately, and users with visual and auditory complications will be aided significantly in this regard.

Google Docs – Key Features for Modern Business Collaboration

Google Docs is a word processing tool, very alike in nature in comparison with Microsoft Word, however it is a cloud-based application withing Googles Workspace, Googles answer to the Microsoft suite. It holds its own in the business world due to being able to allow "multiple users to view, edit, collaborate on documents in real time from any location".[25] Having numerous team members collaborate on a singular document or multiple together in real-time is the most sought out feature in the business world as it significantly enhances productivity within staff which streamlines the work flow heavily for remote, global work.[25] The typical issue that all cloud-based technology suffers from is internet issues flaring up, a common issue that many users face when using Google Docs, resulting in only being able to view the most recent update without the ability to edit the content due to being online[26]. To circumvent the network errors, a very handy feature is the automatic save function, it passively saves your work every couple of minutes without the users need to manually save the work, as human error such as fatigue or simple forgetfulness could lose hours' worth of work if there wasn't such a feature, file errors, computer crashes, power outages, anything that could disrupt workflow is negated due to this one amazing feature, for everybody editing the document so nothing will ever be "lost" it will be held in Google Drive.[26] A dual highlight its user-friendly option for file sharing, rather than having to save the file or export it as a certain file type, all the user has to do is basically click the 'Share' button, enter the email addresses of those you wish to share the document with, and set their permissions, ranging from view-only to full edit rights, which helps avoid accidental edits and keep any sensitive information private due to having the controlled access feature. Work turnaround is significant sped up since choices, corrections, and contributions through collaboration now can happen instantly rather than waiting for emails and having to send files back and forth which would already be outdated, also saving space on the computer due to not having to store a cluster of outdated files whilst also being able to keep all documents and files safely on googles drive with the autosave feature running in the background, greatly reducing missing files.[25] As aforementioned, this is a duel highlight as due to Google Docs being cloud based, users may use their smartphones, tablets, laptops and relatively any device that supports Wi-Fi connectivity which can use can Google Docs browser based extension, as it is a cross platform application, available on MacOS and Windows, a user only has to download the Google Docs Application or use a search engine such as Firefox Mozilla or Opera and Google natively.

2. Test one feature of a freely available Communication (1) and one feature of a Collaboration (1) application and document several screenshots with brief accompanying description to provide evidence of practical use.

Microsoft Teams- Communication

I used Microsoft Teams to demonstrate its communication feature. I used Teams because it allows users to send instant messages & file sharing. The screenshot (Descending from Figure C) shows the chat interface where I sent a message at first and after I attached a two files.

Screenshot 2 displays a message I sent containing “Hey here is the file I was meant to send you!” along with attached documents. This shows how Teams supports both messaging and the transmission of files, images, and documents directly within the chat which are available to view/edit and download instantly and can be responded to in real time, also the user may attach and send local files and or cloud files simultaneously with an option to flag any outgoing mail/messages as important.

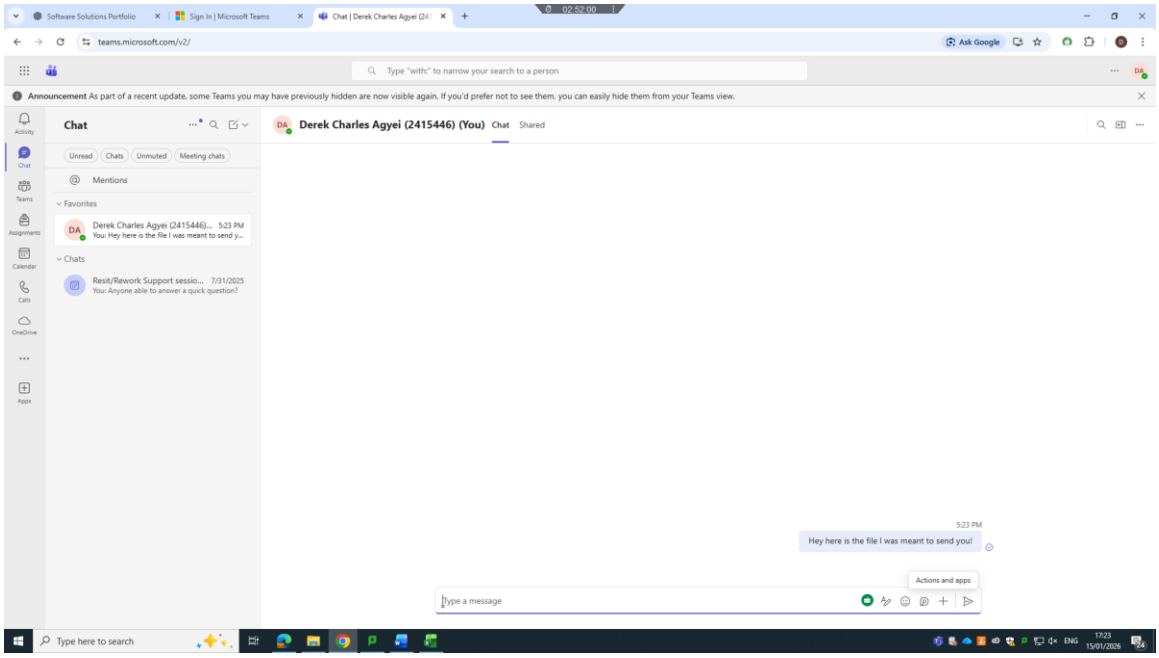

Figure C screenshot 1

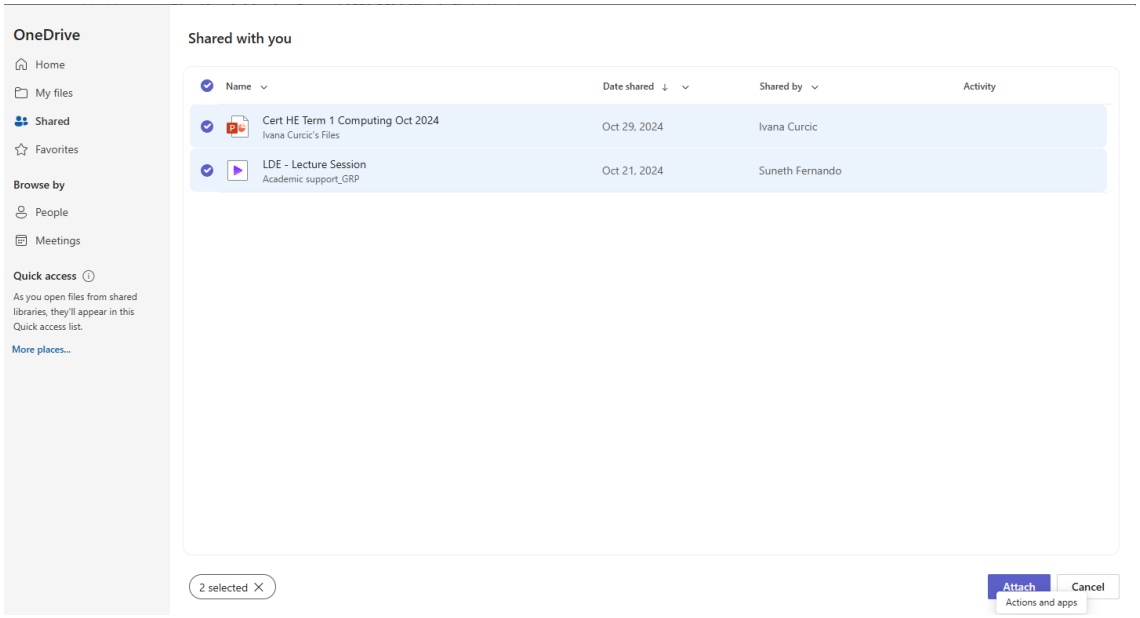

Figure C screenshot 2

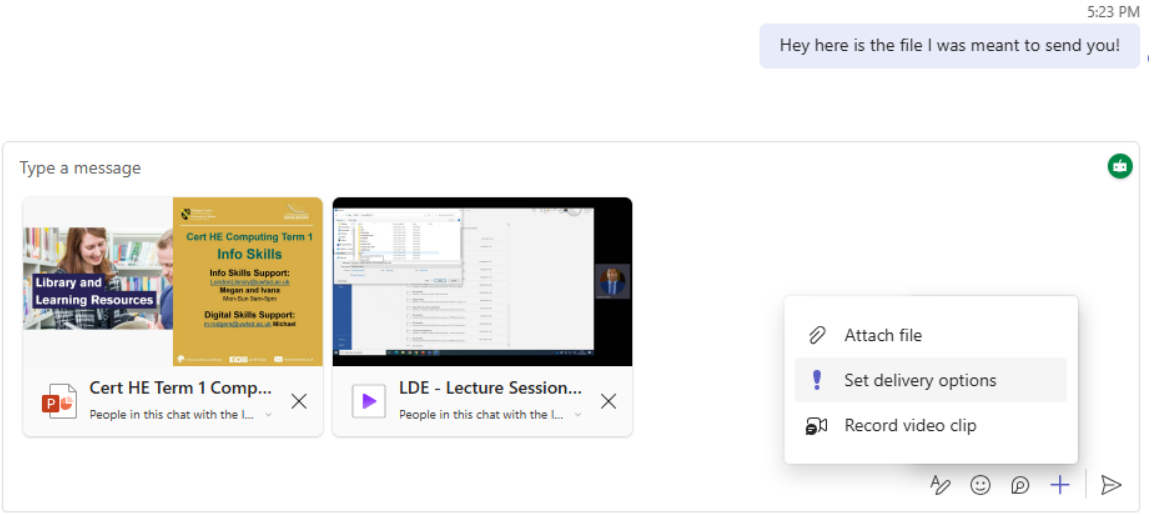

Figure C screenshot 3

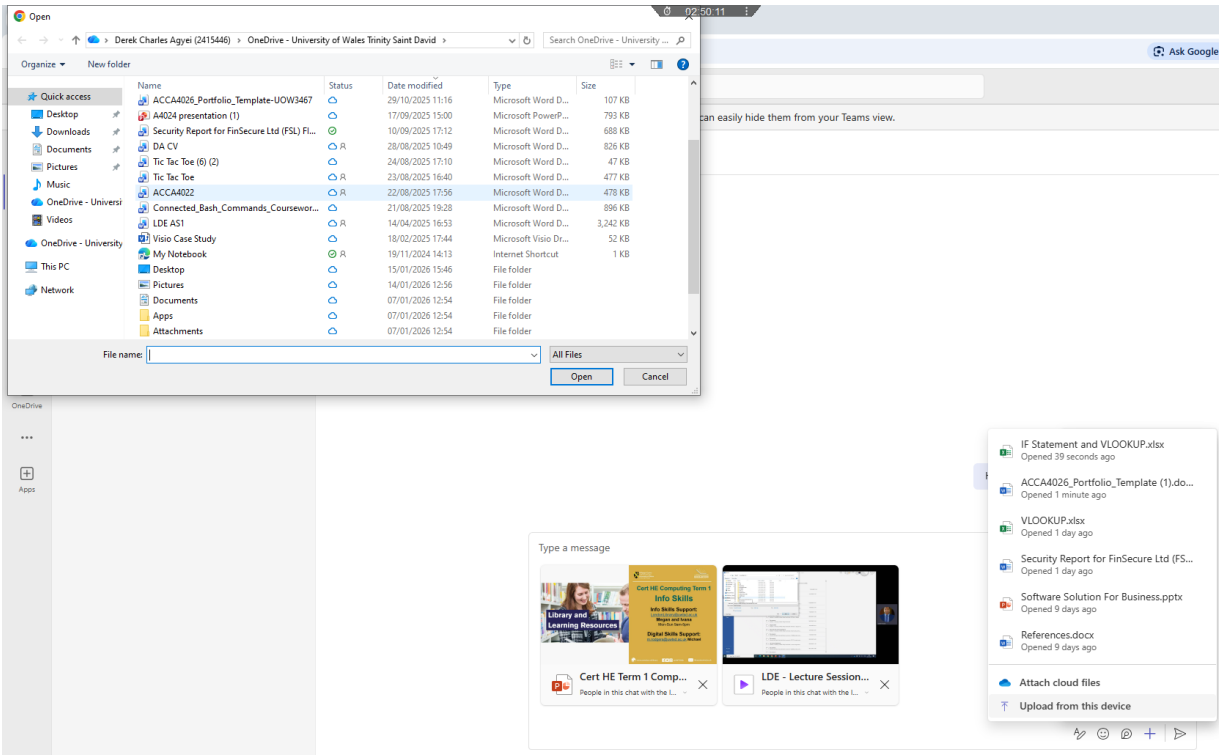

Figure C screenshot 4

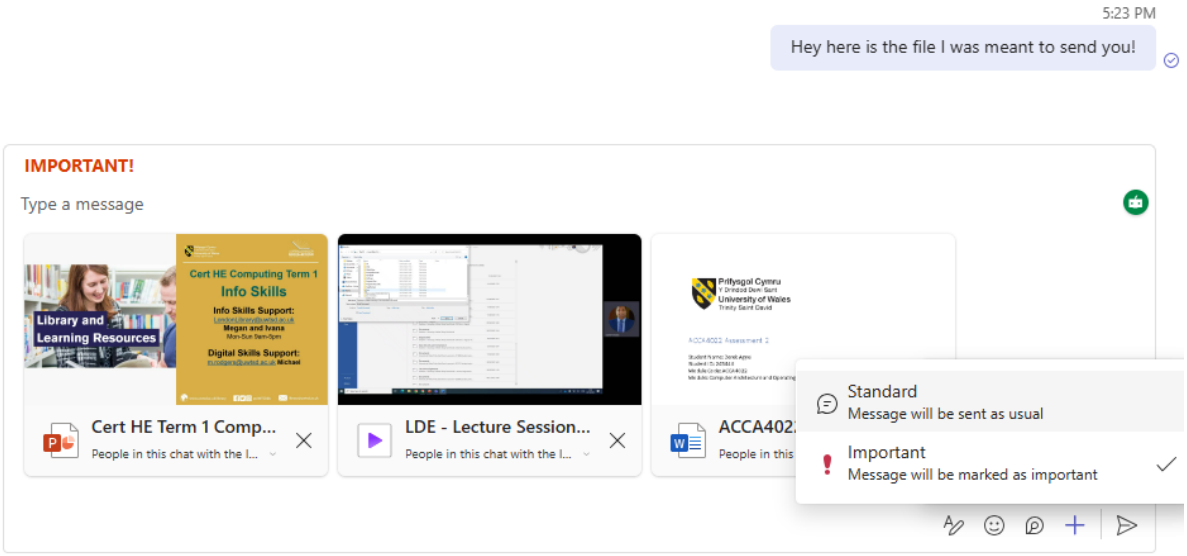

Figure C screenshot 5

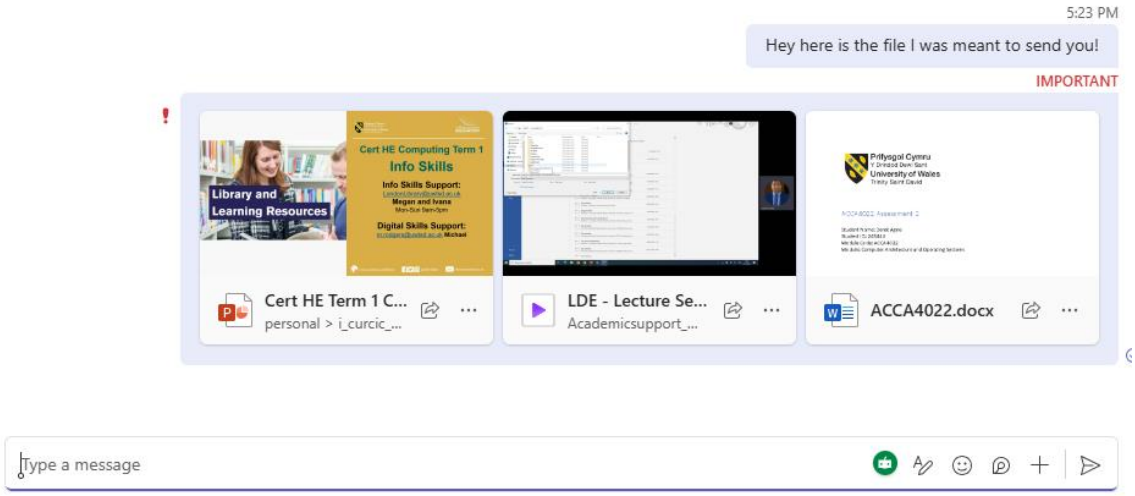

Figure C screenshot 6

Google Docs- Collaboration

I used Google Docs to demonstrate its collaboration feature which allows a document to be shared and edited by more than one user at the same time. As seen in Figure D (Screenshot 1-5 in descending order) Screenshot 1, I opened the Google Docs file. This shows the document layout and the editing interface before sharing. In screenshot 2 I pressed the “Share” button which opened the permissions window. From here I could assign roles such as Viewer, Commenter, and Editor. Additionally, I added another user by email and set the initial permission to “Viewer”. This means the other user can open and read the document through the link but cannot edit the content until the role is changed from “Viewer”. Screenshot 4, I copied the shareable link (accessible to all) generated by Google Docs. This link can be opened in a browser without having to send attachments or saving/sending multiple file versions to individuals, or groups, you can make a link that only authorised personnel may view the documents. Lastly, the link was opened in a new tab to confirm it worked. The shared document loaded successfully, showing that another user can access and edit the file in real time.

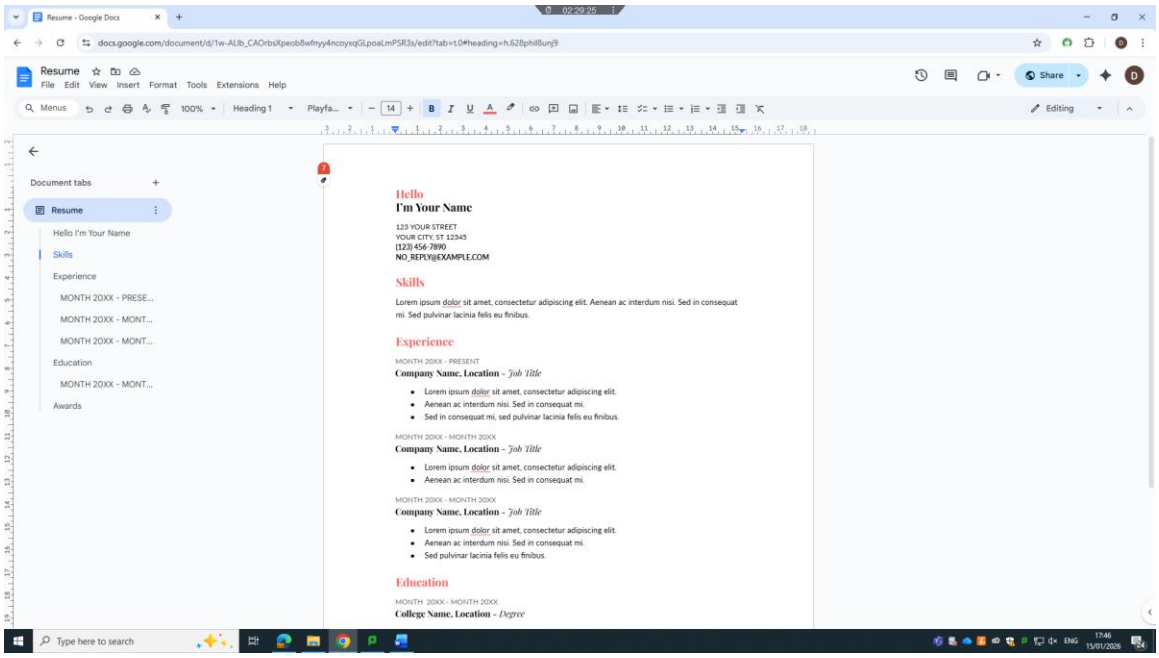

Figure D screenshot 1

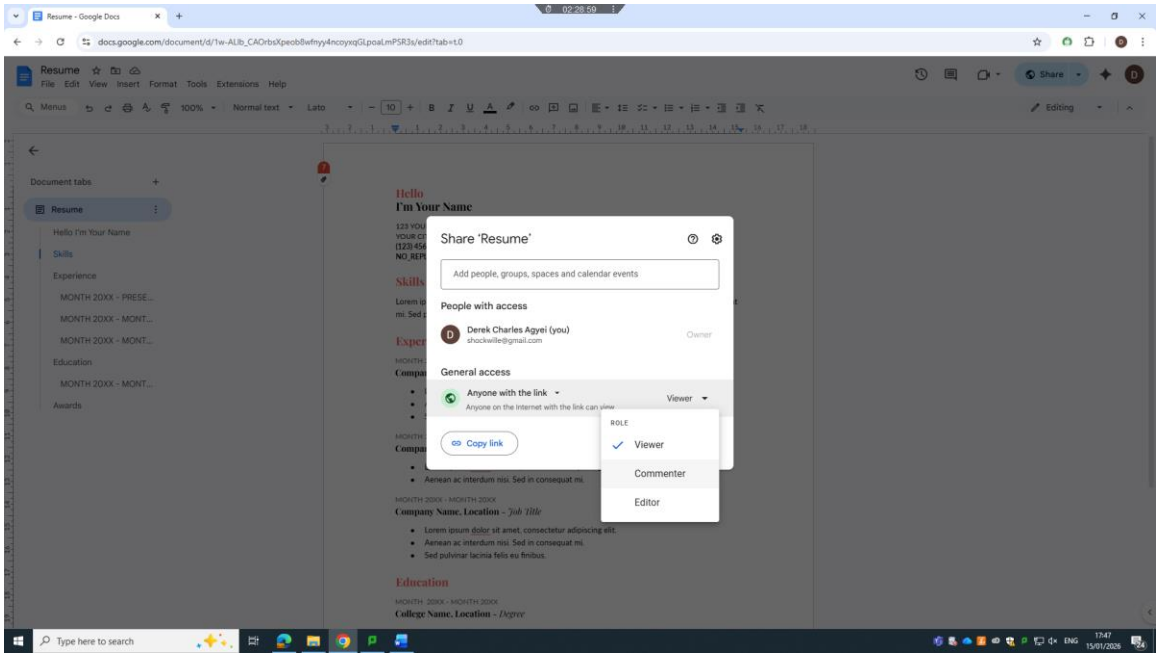

Figure D screenshot 2

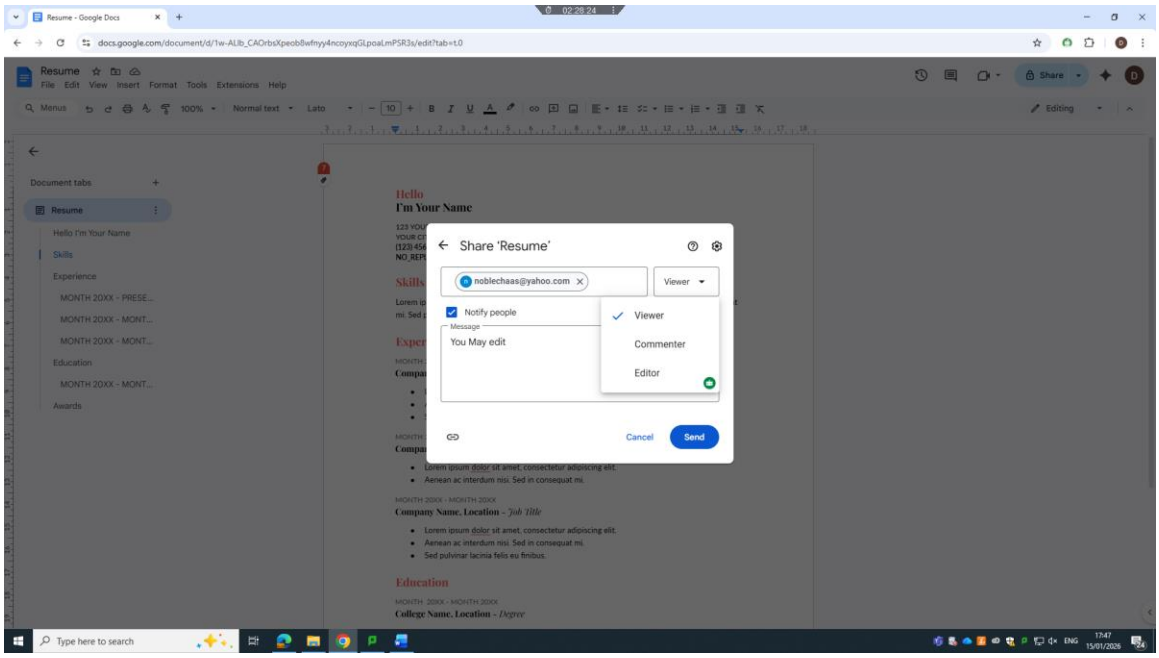

Figure D screenshot 3

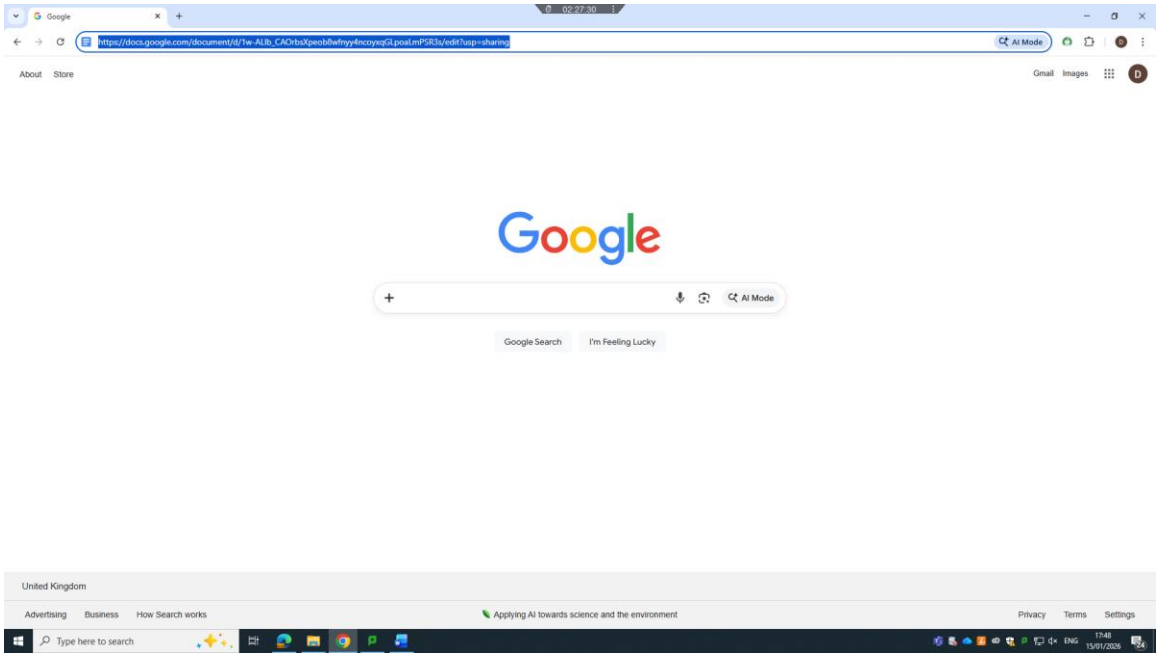

Figure D Screenshot 4

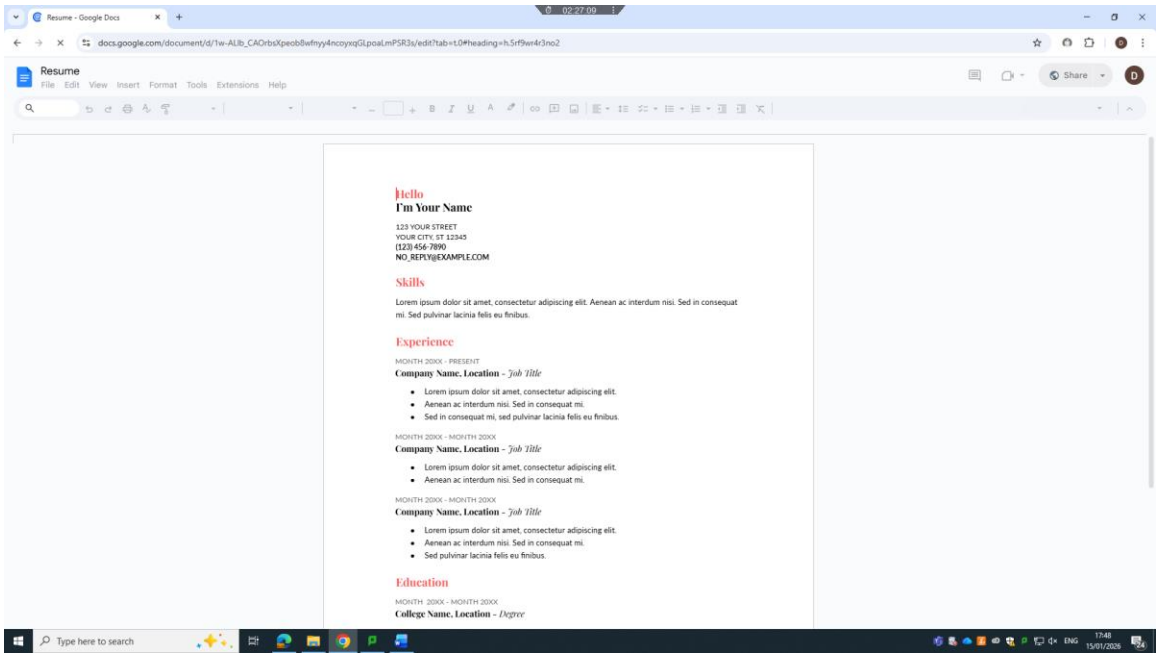

Figure D Screenshot 5

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